



Photography by BANDEEP SINGH. Girl's outfit by MANGO

childhood in '50s America, *The Life and Times of the Thunderbolt Kid*, says that sex was a lot easier to get without money during his boyhood years, and one of the reasons was that *Playboy* came without the plastic jacket, so you could just flip through it while your parents were buying groceries. In India, the best known local porn website, *desibaba.com*, faced an untimely demise a few years ago, although new versions still operate. But that could be the problem of the new millennium. Everything, not just the magazines, comes in a jacket now. People wear clothes at Woodstock revival concerts and the naked dress is a dress that makes sure you're not naked. There's even the Immoral Traffic (Prevention) Act (ITPA) of 1956 and its proposed amendment dealing with sex work in India, which is so heavily cloaked that we don't even know what is legal and what isn't.

But that is precisely why the powers that be should take into account the INDIA TODAY-AC Nielsen-ORG MARG sex survey. A fourth of the male respondents in this country approve of sex with prostitutes, and a fifth admit to having had sex with them. Clearly, in a country where sex doesn't come easy, paying for it seems to be the way to go about it. This is even more evident in the so-called traditional towns where sex is still an unutterable word. The men of Chennai (30 per cent), Ludhiana (33 per cent), Ahmedabad (25 per cent) and Hyderabad (22 per cent) have had much more sex with prostitutes than those in Delhi, Kolkata or Mumbai, which have much more accessibility to the trade. Clearly, money is the answer to everything. Or so say the respondents, 15 per cent of which claim they have always paid for the sex they have had.

It is certainly a time when paid sex is becoming more and more acceptable, be it in the virtual or real world. Pornography, for example, seems to have gripped the nation. About 62 per cent of Indian men like pornography and what's surprising is, even those who don't like it have still watched it (73 per cent). And pornography seems to have become a social activity, and even one of those things that couples do together considering that 40 per cent of the users watch it with partners and 47 per cent with friends. Anyway, half of the country watches pornography and a little less than that watched it as teenagers, so here's guessing visual sex has found its place in the sun.

As for actual sex, if paid sex is on its decline in the metros, is it to be deduced that